Automatic Image Captioning

Abhishek
School of advanced sciences
Vellore institute of technology, Vellore.
abhishek.2020@vitstudent.ac.in

Sandhiya
School of advanced sciences
Vellore institute of technology, Vellore.
sandhiya.r2020@vitstudent.ac.in

Abu Talha
School of advanced sciences
Vellore institute of technology, Vellore.
muhammedabutalha.sa2020@vitstudent.ac.in

Manimaran A
School of advanced sciences
Vellore institute of technology, Vellore.
manimaran.a@vit.ac.in

***Abstract*—**Automated image captioning is a challenging task that involves generating textual descriptions for images. In order to create precise picture captioning systems, this research investigates the developments in deep learning approaches, including convolutional neural network (CNN) and recurrent neural network (RNN). The research focuses on understanding the underlying mechanisms of these networks, their integration, as well as the evaluation parameters that are applied to judge the Caliber of generated captions. Additionally, the paper discusses the challenges, current trends, and future directions in the area of automatic picture captioning. With the help of this research, we aim to contribute to the enhancement of image understanding and natural language processing, ultimately advancing the capabilities of automated image captioning systems.

Keywords— Automated image captioning - Deep learning - Convolutional neural networks (CNN) - Recurrent neural networks (RNN) - Image understanding - Natural language processing (NLP).

I. Introduction

Automated image captioning, the process of generating descriptive text for images automatically, has attracted a lot of interest lately because of its possible uses in a number of industries, including assistive technology, computer vision, and artificial intelligence. This research paper explores the advancements in deep learning models, particularly convolutional neural network (CNN) and recurrent neural network (RNN), to generate accurate and meaningful captions for the images. By combining the visual understanding capabilities of CNNs with the sequential processing power of RNNs, automated image captioning systems have shown remarkable progress in producing human-like descriptions for a wide range of images. This paper aims to explore the underlying mechanisms, challenges, evaluation metrics, and future directions in the field of automated image captioning.

II. Literature Review

Recent advancements in automated image captioning have been driven by the integration of deep learning techniques, particularly CNNs and RNNs. The Show and Tell model and the Show, Attend, and Tell model have been pivotal in this regard, introducing the use of CNN for image feature extraction and LSTM networks for captions generation, in addition to attentional processes that enhance caption accuracy. The adoption of pre-trained CNNs like VGG-16 and ResNet has become standard practice, significantly improving model performance, especially with limited training data. Additionally, reinforcement learning techniques, as shown by Rennie et al. (2017), have been effective in optimizing caption generation by rewarding models for generating more human-like descriptions. These advancements highlight a broader trend in using deep learning, attention mechanisms, and reinforcement learning to enhance automated image captioning systems, leading to more sophisticated and context-aware image description generation models.

III. Why Automatic Image Captioning

Automatic image captioning is a transformative technology with wide-ranging benefits. It enhances accessibility and inclusivity by providing descriptive captions for individuals with visual impairments, ensuring everyone can engage with online visual content. This technology also improves user experience by offering additional context to images, saves time for content creators and users by swiftly generating accurate descriptions, and boosts SEO for websites by increasing visibility and traffic. In educational settings, automatic image captioning aids in creating detailed descriptions for educational materials, presentations, and online learning resources, catering to diverse learning styles and enhancing knowledge retention. These benefits underscore the significance of automatic image captioning across various domains, making it a valuable tool in today's digital landscape.

IV. Methodology

A. *Data set*

The dataset comprises 8,000 images, with each image having five associated captions. Features from both the images and captions are extracted for input. To predict the next word in the caption, the features are combined. Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks are used to process text features, while Convolutional Neural Networks (CNN) are used to analyze image features. The performance of the model is evaluated using the BLEU Score metric.

B. *Feature extraction*

To extract features from images using the VGG16 model, the code snippet iterates through a directory containing images, loading each image one by one. Each image is then resized to 224x224 pixels, converted into a numpy array, reshaped to fit the model's input shape, and

preprocessed for VGG16. Subsequently, the image is passed through the VGG16 model to extract features that capture essential visual information. These extracted features are stored in a dictionary where the image ID serves as the key, extracted from the image name, and the feature vector as the value. This procedure makes it possible to extract picture features efficiently, which may then be applied to tasks like content-based image retrieval, image classification, and similarity comparison.

C. *Loading and storing captions*

We read the caption from a text file. the captions are converted from a list to a string format. A mapping dictionary is created to associate each image ID with its captions. If a new image ID is encountered, a new list is created to store its captions, and additional captions are appended to this list. This mapping process establishes a connection between images and their descriptive captions, enriching the interpretation and analysis of the image content.

D. *Preprocess text data*

The process includes changing the text to lowercase, getting rid of non-alphabetic characters like numbers and symbols, eliminating extra spaces, and including special tags at the beginning and end of captions to enhance analysis.

```
# before preprocess of text
mapping['1000268201_693b08cb0e']
```

```
['A child in a pink dress is climbing up a set of stairs in an entry way .',
 'A girl going into a wooden building .',
 'A little girl climbing into a wooden playhouse .',
 'A little girl climbing the stairs to her playhouse .',
 'A little girl in a pink dress going into a wooden cabin .']
```

Fig. 1. Before preprocessing

```
# after preprocess of text
mapping['1000268201_693b08cb0e']
```

```
['startseq child in pink dress is climbing up set of stairs in an entry way endseq',
 'startseq girl going into wooden building endseq',
 'startseq little girl climbing into wooden playhouse endseq',
 'startseq little girl climbing the stairs to her playhouse endseq',
 'startseq little girl in pink dress going into wooden cabin endseq']
```

Fig. 2. After preprocessing

V. MODEL ARCHITECTURE

Image captioning models use an encoder-decoder architecture to turn images into captions. A pre-trained CNN in the encoder extracts visual features from the image, while an LSTM in the decoder processes captions (sequences of words) and understands their structure. These features are then combined to allow the decoder's LSTM to generate captions word by word, considering both the image content and the caption being built so far. The final layer predicts the probability of each word in the vocabulary, essentially choosing the most likely word to add next to the caption.

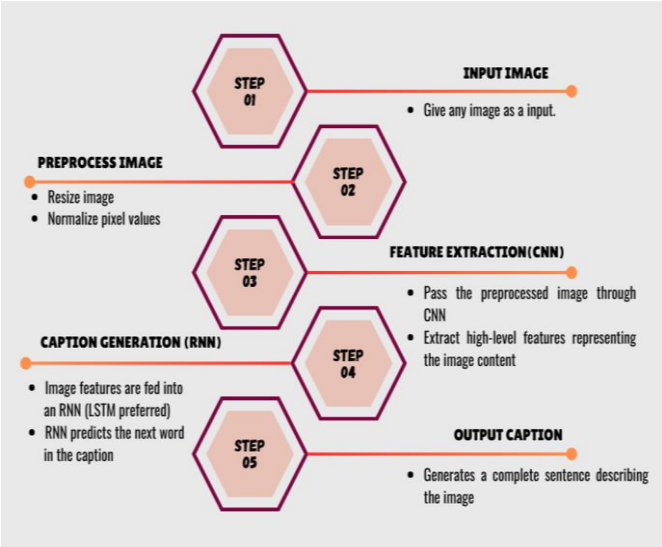

Fig. 3. Working flowchart

VI. TRAINING

We choose a batch size of 32 and a number of epochs of 20. The training data is split into batches for every epoch, and the model is trained on these batches. The data generator function prepares the data for training by creating batches of input-output pairs. The model is then trained for one epoch using the generated data. This process is repeated for each epoch to improve the model's ability to generate accurate captions for images.

VII. TESTING

```
--------------------Actual--------------------
startseq black dog and spotted dog are fighting endseq
startseq black dog and tri-colored dog playing with each other on the road endseq
startseq black dog and white dog with brown spots are staring at each other in the street endseq
startseq two dogs of different breeds looking at each other on the road endseq
startseq two dogs on pavement moving toward each other endseq
--------------------Predicted--------------------
startseq two dogs play with each other in the grass endseq
```

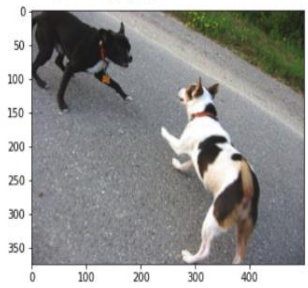

Fig. 4. Predicted caption 1

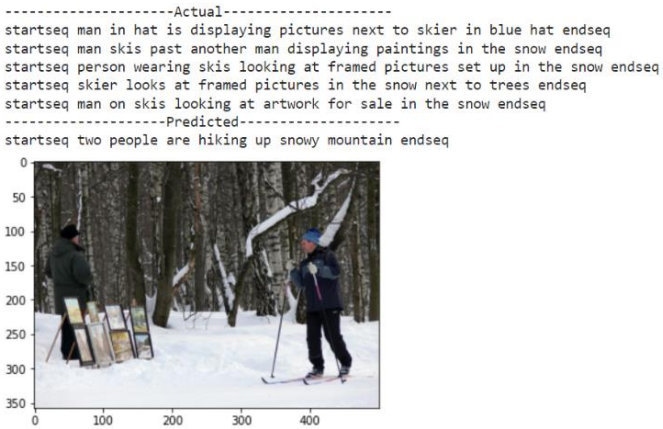

Fig. 5. Predicted caption 2

VIII. DISCUSSION

Deep learning has demonstrated potential in image captioning, but challenges persist.. Limited training data can restrict performance. Future work should explore techniques to make better use of existing data and incorporate information from social media. Additionally, current models may struggle with complex scenes and generate repetitive captions. Future research could address this by incorporating attention mechanisms and training models to produce diverse captions that reflect different interpretations and go beyond basic descriptions, potentially leveraging knowledge graphs to provide more comprehensive explanations. By overcoming these limitations, automatic image captioning systems can become more robust and generate informative captions that enhance user experience across various applications.

IX. CONCLUSION

Automatic image captioning has shown great promise in transforming the way we engage with visual content. This study examined the developments in deep learning, with a focus on recurrent neural networks (RNN) and convolutional neural networks (CNN) for generating accurate and human-like captions for images. The integration of these networks has enabled significant progress in image captioning systems. The paper reviewed the underlying mechanisms of CNNs and RNNs, their effective combination in encoder-decoder architectures, and the metrics used to evaluate the quality of generated captions.

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